# JBL Bar 1300 MK2

## This is what Dolby Atmos from a soundbar actually sounds like

₹1,50,000




If you ever go out in the market looking to buy a soundbar, you will find the words 'Dolby Atmos' appear on products spanning a wide price range but the actual Atmos experience across that range varies dramatically. At one end sits a single bar with no height drivers and a DSP algorithm doing its best to simulate spatial audio. At the other sits a proper home theatre system with physical up-firing drivers at both the front and the rear, a wireless subwoofer with enough output to be felt rather than just heard. The JBL Bar 1300 MK2, at Rs 1,50,000 for the complete package without a doubt occupies the second category. It includes the main soundbar, a wireless dual-driver subwoofer and two detachable battery-powered rear speakers. There are 29 drivers distributed across these three components and every channel in the 11.1.4 configuration has at least one physical driver assigned to it.

What the Bar 1300 MK2 delivers in the right room, at the right volume and with the rear speakers correctly positioned is the closest a soundbar system currently gets to what a proper Dolby Atmos speaker installation produces. Getting there requires patience with the calibration process, some time with the EQ to tame the default bass level and positioning the rear speakers where they need to be. For buyers who have that patience and the content to reward it, the experience on the other side is possibly one of the best in this category..

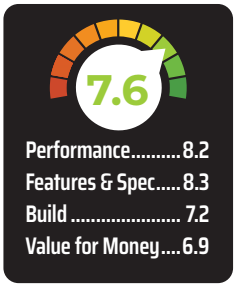
### SETUP AND THE JBL ONE APP

Setup is fairly direct and you just need to connect the soundbar to the television's eARC port via the included HDMI cable, plug the subwoofer into a power source and the three components pair automatically. No manual pairing between the bar, subwoofer and rear speakers is required.

The JBL One app handles network connection, room calibration and ongoing adjustments. The calibration process asks you to detach the rear speakers, place them at the primary listening position first and then at the rear listening position. The system plays test tones and adjusts to your room's acoustics. Placing the rear speakers at ear height directly behind the listening position, rather than wide of it, produces a tighter and more cohesive surround field. The calibration adapts to wherever you place them and the difference is perceptible.

The app provides a seven-band EQ, adjustable rear channel level, adjustable height level and sound mode presets including Movie, Music and Standard. PureVoice 2.0, the dialogue enhancement feature, is context-aware rather than a blunt frequency boost. In quiet dialogue scenes its effect is imperceptible. In busy action sequences, it brings vocal clarity forward without making speech sound artificially separated from the soundtrack. This is a significantly more intelligent implementation than most soundbar dialogue enhancement features, which typically introduce sibilance while fixing one problem and creating another.

SmartDetails and AI Sound Boost are both active by default and cannot be switched off individually. SmartDetails prioritises subtle audio detail in complex soundscapes. AI Sound Boost manages subwoofer dynamics at high output levels. Neither introduces audible artefacts in normal use and the inability to disable them is a minor frustration rather than a practical problem.




### FILMS

With the rear speakers detached and positioned correctly, the Bar 1300 MK2 produces a surround field with spatial breadth. Objects arriving from the rear are positioned there by physical drivers reproducing actual rear channel information, not front-stage processing. Above and behind the listening position, the rear speakers' up-firing height drivers contribute to the overhead sound layer. Combined with the front height drivers in the main bar, Dolby Atmos content has both a front-to-rear axis and a vertical axis that most soundbar systems at any price cannot match with physical hardware.

The overhead height effect is most convincing when content is mixed to use it specifically. Sequences with aircraft, falling debris, ambient environmental sound or weather effects over-